

Reconciling rationalism and empiricism



Until late in his career, Immanuel Kant was a rationalist – he claimed that he was awoken from this ‘dogmatic slumber’ by reading the works of Hume (see [Hume and causality](#)), and was also influenced by scientific advances to admit the importance of empirically derived evidence. He set about reconciling the two apparently opposing theories of rationalism and empiricism in his 1781 magnum opus, the *Critique of Pure Reason*. Kant argued that we have what he called a ‘sensibility’, enabling us to recognize objects in space and time, but also an ‘understanding’ of concepts such as space, time and substance. He called these concepts ‘categories’ of

understanding (including substance, quantity, quality, relation and modality), and reasoned that, since we must have knowledge of these concepts in order to understand the things we recognize empirically, they must be *a priori*, or innate. So, while we get to know some things about the world empirically, through our bodily senses, prior to that experience we innately understand the parameters, the ‘categories’, that define them.